and geographic distance from its rivals, it could well restrict its exertions to homeland and hemispheric defence, the security of Australia and the UK, and the protection of Japan. Even this limited international role is open to question in light of something that Beckley largely ignores: the US's massive internal political polarization and its susceptibility to foreign interference and influence operations.

In 2012, in my column for the *Times of India* just days after Barack Obama was elected president for the second time, I wrote this about the US: 'Perhaps the greatest worry is the white middle class and upper middle class. A very large proportion of this class has become ever more resentful of Obama, the Democratic Party, minorities, government, and liberal values. Some sections of it are feeling the bite of an increasingly unequal America . . . A middle class that is on the slide downwards is a dangerous force . . . Could the unthinkable eventually happen in the US? Could a large chunk of the US choose to secede . . .?'[20] Eight years later, the internal churn of the US is even greater. Writing in the *New York Times* on 29 September 2020, after the presidential debate between Donald Trump and Joe Biden, Thomas Friedman, the American columnist, sounded a desperate warning bell:

> I can't say this any more clearly: Our democracy is in terrible danger – more danger than it has been since the Civil War, more danger than after Pearl Harbor, more danger than during the Cuban missile crisis and more danger than during Watergate . . . I began my career as a foreign correspondent covering Lebanon's second civil war . . . I saw what happens in a country when everything becomes politics, when a critical mass of politicians put party before country, when responsible people, or seemingly responsible people, think that they can bend or break the rules – and go all the way – and that the system won't break . . . But when extremists go all the way, and moderates just go away, the system can break. And it will break. I saw it happen.[21]

The Lebanonization of the US, helped along as Lebanon was by foreign interference, is perhaps not as far-fetched as I had imagined in 2012.

Weeks after Friedman wrote his despairing column, Donald Trump lost the US presidential elections. It would be naive to think, though, that with his defeat the dangers to America's democracy and internal peace have disappeared: the storming of the US Capitol by Trump supporters on 6